Women* Sitting at the Machine, Thinking

Acknowledgement

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Dedicated to

Karen Brodine

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Appendix 8—Statement of Originality

This is to certify that to the best of my knowledge, the content of this thesis is my own work. This thesis has not previously been submitted for any degree or other purposes. I certify that the intellectual content of this thesis is the product of my own work and that all the assistance received in preparing this thesis and sources have been acknowledged.

Signed
Malva Askerup

The Bitters Column is a bi-monthly publication about forming a feminist graphic design practice in conversation with others. This is the fifth—and special—issue, publishing a text titled 'Women* Sitting at the Machine, Thinking', written as an expanded editorial note of sorts, meditating on four words: 'to form a practice'. Each column of the publication responds to a source of inspiration in relation to how feminist politics can be applied in critical editorial practices, such as how to approach typography, printing, and publishing. This text reflects on the making of the first three issues in March 2026. [Fig. 0] The structure is divided into three columns: the edge column recalls conversations with present voices in one's own community, with a classmate and practitioners in the field. The center column is dedicated to a radical thinker from the past: the Marxist-feminist writer, typesetter, and poet Karen Brodine, as a dream conversation of sorts. The gutter column is an inquiry into archival material from the '70s feminist print activism movement, in conversation with librarian Lisbeth Jørgensen at Kvindehuset—The Women's House in Copenhagen. All together proposing ways of working in different collective formations with print and form-based structures that make discussion of the political.

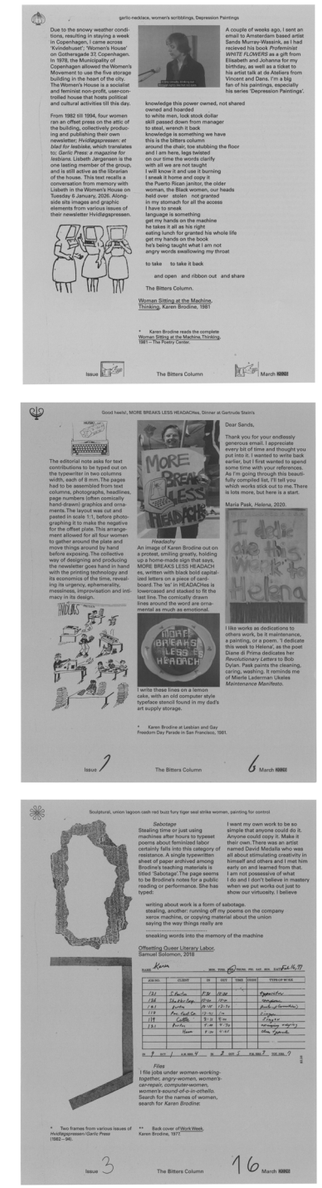

Fig. 0. Askerup, *The Bitters Collumn* Issue 1, 2, and 3, March 2026.

The inquiry of this publication started in August 2025, as I was a resident at Rietlanden Women's Office (RWO) in Amsterdam, with the co-founders and designers Elisabeth Rafstedt and Johanna Ehde. As we were planning how we would spend our time together over these four months, I confessed my desire to form a life-long feminist practice, and they offered to help. Their personal support covered not only the time shared at work, but in all aspects of life, such as finding housing, meeting people, and getting a bike. Support in this sense resonated well with a text by the poet Eileen Myles, where she writes: [Fig. 1]

> There is a word in Italian, *affidamento*, which describes a relationship of trust between two women, in which the younger asks the elder to help her obtain something she desires. Women I know are turning around to see if that woman is here. The woman turning, that's the revolution. The room is gigantic, the woman is here.[1]

'The Lesbian Poet' was republished in 2012, within a book titled 'Revolution: A Reader' collected and annotated by the poet Lisa Robertson and writer Matthew Stadler. The book is a 1200-page portrait of revolutionary thought, putting forward the marginal as a site for resistance, where Robertson's and Stadler's annotations amplify, complicate, and respond to the texts and to each other. The construction of the book is a revolutionary act of collaboration and manifesto for a future of joyous collective change. In the margin of Myles' text, Robertson's annotation responds:

> Eileen is saying something so profoundly necessary and basic and sometimes forgotten. Something marketless. We help one another carry our dearest thoughts, our most careful desires, forward. We turn to race one another as humans on a wobbling edge. That's where trust is. The one who can help does so. This turning is the gesture of the beginning of a community where a community only ever begins.[2]

Affidamento translates from Italian to entrustment, and was used by The Milan Women's Bookstore co-operative

1. Myles, *The Lesbian Poet, Revolution: A Reader*, ed. Lisa Robertson and Matthew Stadler (Portland, OR: Publication Studio, 2012), 438.

2. Myles, *The Lesbian Poet*, 118.

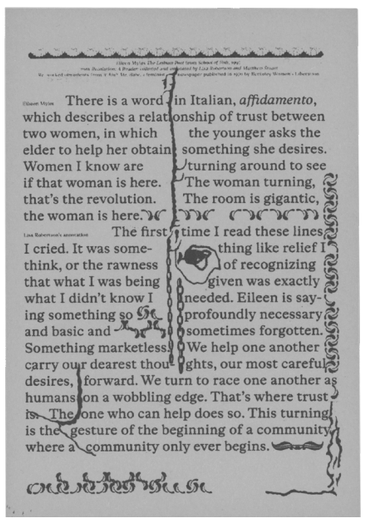

Fig. 1. Askerup, *Affidamento*, A6 riso printed postcard, 2026. Quote from Myles and Robertson with re-worked ornaments from feminist newspaper *It Ain't me Babe* published in 1970 by Berkeley Women's Liberation.

'to describe an ancient relational form as an indispensable way for women to achieve what they desire'.[3] This word felt present in my experience at RWO, in Rafstedt's and Ehde's ways of working together, from writing emails aloud, to all three of us standing around one computer—always in conversation with each other and the design. As a reflection on their work methods and ethics, I started writing and editing texts that spoke to me, sourced from the bookshelf at RWO and my personal archive, compiling an index or manifesto of sorts about shaping a critical editorial practice. For me, *critical* is dedication to a life-long practice of feminist thinking through making in collaboration with others (despite the forces that strive for separation), and engaging with material as a way of living in it.

Whilst roaming the bookshelf at RWO, I came across a conversation between the artist Celine Condorelli and writer Avery F. Gordon (2013), where Condorelli says:

> I work by spending time with things I have collected, the references that I carry along, like friendly voices in my head, which also include the essential voices of inspirational thinkers from those that populate my thoughts and conversations and in this way, also present. Friendship then, is perhaps a condition of work in my practice—a fundamental aspect of personal support, a condition for doing things together.[4]

As Rafstedt and Ehde offered to let me use their studio every Wednesday, I shared Condorelli's text with peers, and we started meeting regularly for lunch. These gatherings sparked friendships, and revealed a longing of coming together around editorial matters and events, and led to organising a karaoke bar and a quilting club for Palestine. One of the collaborators was my classmate Jaehyun Kim, and from this reading we started printing together with PANTONE[5] colours in the letterpress workshop in school.

3. Alex Martinis Roe, *To Become Two: Propositions for Feminist Collective Practice*, chap. 2 (Berlin: Archive Books, 2018), 57.

4. Condorelli and Gordon, *The Company We Keep, PERSONA*, Issue 2 (2013), 14.

5. PANTONE colours: a proprietary, standardized colour swatch profile, that I was gifted by Rafstedt and Ehde on my last day in the office.

Condorelli's text stayed in the back of our heads and informed us how our friendship was a condition for working together. We edited three texts by Condorelli and offset printed an A2 poster in two layers: our edited text in the center, and images and annotations from shared work-life in the large margins. [Fig. 2] Her writing spoke to us, particularly in this part:

> Friendship in these terms cannot be based simply on utility or pleasure, but as a desire for the other to exist, as a desire for life, and for cohabitation within it. This is the idea of living together and sharing acts and thoughts in common, so that what is shared is not property, but an activity, a process of co-existence through doing and thinking.[6]

Here, Condorelli puts forward a desire for cohabitation as an active process merging friendship and work. In working together within the institution where we study (KABK), we noticed clashes and contradictions with one's desire to lustfully make under the pressure of delivering expectations. These conditions made for a sense of loneliness, when moving towards developing separate graduation works, as an embodied experience of structural competition (who did what?), and racial and class privilege (who has time and space?). When working side-by-side, we had to be careful not to repeat a certain division of labor and efficient working methods, where the intellect separates from material practices. We became aware that working collectively is not an embodied utopia—it reveals power structures and hierarchies that are also political and murky. Practising graphic design in collaboration with others proposes slow processes, with all its hesitations and conflicts included.

As I mediated on collective practices, I came back to Robertson, in another of her texts titled 'The Collective' (2019), where she concludes:

> But now I believe that what the collective produced most importantly was a mode of autonomous, plural existence. Deeply, almost like animals, they understood how to live together. They made for a moment a precariously inhabitable social sculpture.[7]

This idea of an inhabitable social sculpture resonated with the publication I was compiling at RWO, originating from a desire to share texts one feels close to, and working with friends, which developed to The Bitters Column: a small-scale publishing project with a local readership—calling out for a plurality of past and present voices to merge on the page.

6. Condorelli, *Too Close to See: A Conversation with Johan Frederik Hartle*, in *Self Organised* (London: Open Editions, 2013), 70.

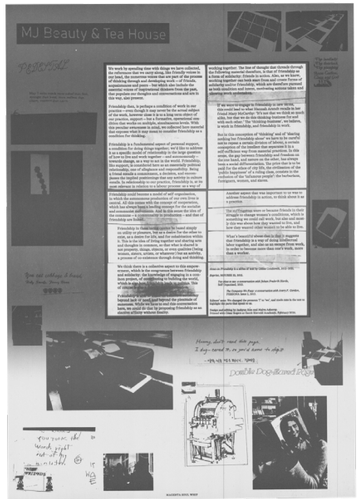

Fig. 2. Askerup, Kim, *MAGENTA SOUL WHIP*, offset printed A2 poster, 2026. Three edited texts from Condorelli's series titled *Notes on Friendship*, from 2012–2021.

7. Robertson, *The Collective, in New Weathers* (Toronto: Book*hug Press, 2019), 163.

> she thinks about everything at once without making a mistake.
> no one has figured out how to keep her from doing this thinking.[8]

The center column of The Bitters Column is dedicated to a poet's voice, sharing the work of critical thinker Karen Brodine, who has in many ways shaped the form of this publication. [Fig. 3] Karen Brodine was a Marxist-feminist writer, typesetter, activist, and poet, born in Seattle in 1947, and based in San Francisco until 1987, when she tragically passed away at the age of 40 from cancer, both related to the chemical processes of her work as a typesetter, and the medical profession that was profit-motivated and sexist to diagnose her in time.[9]

In 1975, Karen Brodine turned to typesetting to support her livelihood—a skill she loved for its integration of language, and found employment amongst other working-class LGBTQ+ people.[10] In her final book, 'Woman Sitting at the Machine, Thinking' (1990), Brodine talks about the labor relations of typesetting, and in the poem with the same title (1981), she is writing as a typesetter who not only reproduces information but thinks critically while she works. The poem records Brodine at work, as she hates her boss, sympathizes with her colleagues, and daydreams.

In reading it 45 years later, her poem got me *thinking* about typographic labor and collectively in relation to a contemporary feminist graphic design practice.[11] This publication engages with a part of Brodine's poem, where she writes:

> knowledge this power owned, not shared
> owned and hoarded
> to white men, lock stock dollar
> skill passed down from manager
> to steal, wrench it back
> knowledge is something we have
> this is the bitters column
> (...)

8. Karen Brodine, *Woman Sitting at the Machine, Thinking*, (Seattle: Red Letter Press, 1990), 3.

9. Janet Sutherland, *Karen Brodine: Poet, Feminist, Revolutionary, 1947–1987, in Freedom Socialist*, 1988.

10. Brodine worked at Howard Quinn Co. between 1975–86.

11. Such as Loraine Further.

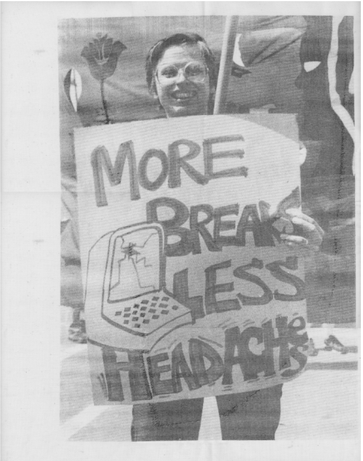

Fig. 3. Askerup, screenprinted A2 banner, 2026. Image of Brodine at Lesbian and Gay Freedom Day Parade in San Francisco, 1981.

> to take to take it back
> and open and ribbon out and share
> The Bitters Column.[12]

What Brodine proposes is for people to take back their knowledge and skills that originate from oppressive structures of capitalism, racism and patriarchy, to share new forms of their skilled work—placing the means of production in the hands of the workers. For this project, I borrowed her term *The Bitters Column*, to *open*, *ribbon out*, and *share* thoughts on graphic design work through typesetting, editing, and publishing.

In a conversation with the publisher Phil Baber about Brodine's work, he emphasised knowing our history of graphic design, understanding that our practice was formed by the working class which had agency on structures. In his work that entails typesetting, he finds pleasure in breaking the lines on the page. Baber brings up Cynthia Cockburn's book (1983), where she writes about the technological shift for compositor workers (typesetters) from Monotype and Linotype hot-metal typesetting to phototypesetting in the end of the '70s. The new technology took away the skill of the worker's autonomy to self decide where to break their lines. The *deskilled* worker altered the gendered structure of the workplace, allowing more women to enter the labor, yet the new jobs were framed as repetitive, automatic, lower-paid, and subordinate. As one of the male compositors said:

> If girls can do it, you know, then you are sort of *deskilled* you know, really.[13]

Brodine was a skilled worker, framed within the new technology of phototypesetting and working under management, where ideals were not always in practice. However, she was looking for pleasures at work, and if the breaking one's own lines suggests a sense of

12. Brodine, *Woman Sitting at the Machine, Thinking*, 11.

13. *Cockburn, Brothers*, in *Male Dominance and Technological Change* (London: Pluto Press, 1983), 118.

freedom, Brodine found inspiration through acts of sabotage, such as sneaking her poetry into the machine:

> a typesetter changes man to person will they catch her?
> She files one job under union,
> another under lagoon,
> another under cash
>
> what if you could send anything in and call it out again?
> I file jobs under words I like—red, buzz, fury
> search for tiger, execute
> the words stream up the screen till tiger trips the halt
> search for seal search for strike
> search for the names of women[14]

Here, Brodine (woman at the machine), engages in various forms of resistance including collective action. The French term *La perrugue* translates to *the wig*, and was used by philosopher Michel de Certeau to describe the 'worker's own work disguised as work for his employer'.[15] *The wig* applies to Brodine, in her use of skills as a typesetter, poet, and organiser, as a source of joy and as a generative part of being with others, rejecting the rhetoric of *deskilling* associated with feminized labor.

Brodine's action motivated the title of this text, as I shifted the pronoun from 'Woman...' to 'Women* Sitting at the Machine, Thinking', as I'm actively looking at women and queer editorial practices, addressing the multitude 'Sitting at the Machine, Thinking'.

Poet and academic writer Samuel Solomon reflects on the title of Brodine's poem in his essay 'Offsetting Queer Literary Labor' (2018), on how LBTQ+ and feminists navigated the shifts in typesetting technologies:

> The placement of *thinking* after the comma affords some ambiguity about the agent of the thinking: woman, machine, or woman-machine. That is *thinking,* is conditioned by rather than simply outside of or beyond the relations of feminized wage labor.[16]

14. Brodine, *Woman Sitting at the Machine, Thinking*, 17.

15. Certeau, *The Practice of Everyday Life* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984), 25.

16. Solomon, *Offsetting Queer Literary Labor*, Version 1 (University of Sussex, 2018), 28.

Solomon brings me back to how working conditions shape our *thinking* of work, determining a one's feelings of loneliness and belonging. In March 2026, we spoke over zoom about Brodine's work. [Fig. 4] Solomon said that part of what her poem imagines is you just get rid of the managers, and that you all controlled everything: to seize the means of production. As it's harder to apply in all aspects of digital graphic design and dealing with cloud servers, he asked, 'What would it mean to own it and hold it? Where is it? Can you take it?' In my response, resistance and sabotage inside the software (that is no better than a boss or a landlord), can't apply in the same way because of its invisibility: to file jobs under *strike* or *fury* will do no harm. Instead, I come back to collaboration as how to approach graphic design tools critically. To design side-by-side in a software that was built to isolate the individual is potentially a form of resistance. Brodine's work is interesting as it's both so collective and in the interior of one person at the same time, giving it richness and breadth, because it's not as simple as saying *collective* and therefore individuals don't matter.

The conversation with Solomon made me think that the desire for some other mode of being in the world is connected to trying to understand the conditions we live and operate within. Thus, I turn to Brodine's *thinking* as a critical editorial practice, questioning our skills as graphic designers and how we want to use them: be it in a linebreak, protesting, or taking turns on the keyboard.

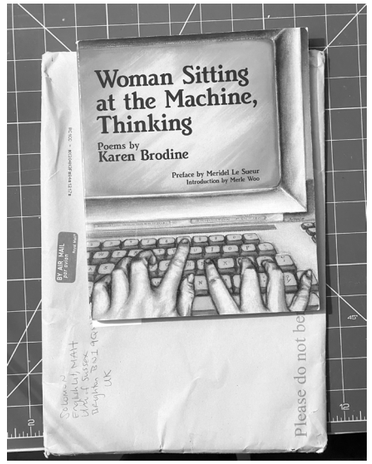

Fig. 4. Solomon generously sent me a copy of *Woman Sitting at the Machine, Thinking*.

The gutter column of The Bitters Column is a research into various publications from the feminist print activism movement in the '70s, looking at the traces of women and queer editorial practices. The rise of radical feminist print and publishing was driven by social shifts in society, along with changes in printing and typesetting technologies. Prior '60s books and newspapers were typeset on Linotype or Monotype machines, a technology that required skilled workers. In the '70s, shifts in typesetting and printing introduced photo-offset, Xerox, mimeograph, and photocopying technologies, putting the means of production into the hands of amateurs and deskilled workers. Self-produced newsletters, pamphlets, and magazines sprung from radical political groups: feminist, Black, and gay liberation, to share ideas within and between movements. The collective labor involved in editing, typesetting, printing, binding, and mailing, dismantled traditional hierarchical roles within editorial work, and was both practical as means to build communities. For these groups, graphic design was not a profession but a practice—a way of thinking, making, and organising.

During my studies, I've been going to archives to look at printed matter from these movements, and even better, meeting members of the collectives that made them. The inspiration for the first issue of The Bitters Column followed a coincidental meeting in January 2026, with the librarian Lisbeth Jørgensen at Kvindehuset—The Woman's House in Copenhagen, operating since 1978 as a feminist non-profit, user-controlled house that hosts political and cultural activities to this day. From 1982 till 1994, four women ran an offset press on the attic of the building, and with all inhabitats of the Woman's House involved, collectively producing and publishing their own newsletter, 'Hvidløgspressen: et blad for lesbiske', which translates to, 'Garlic Press: a magazine for lesbians'. In The Bitters Column, Issue 2, I recalled a fragment of our conversation:

> Jørgensen tells me that the three women she worked together with on the newsletter are all dead today. She emphasises that the work on the press killed them slowly, from breathing in the fumes of deadly chemicals in a crowded attic space for years.[17]

This amplifies Jørgensen's care for the naming of her community, as so much gets lost in the messy history of graphic design. Martha Scotford defines the contrasting *neat history* involving the simple packaging of one white, male, middle-class designer working for a client. *Messy history* then, represents designers who don't work alone but in changing collaborations; design works for local causes at the scale of a *cottage industry*, in practices organised around personal issues and domestic life.[18]

17. Askerup, *The Bitters Column*, Issue 2, 2026.

18. Scotford, *Messy History vs. Neat History: Toward an Expanded View of Women in Graphic Design*, *Visible Language* 28, no. 4 (1994), 371.

Jørgensen gifted me a box of their newsletters, offering their graphic world a source of inspiration. In the making of this publication, I kept returning to their archive, simply intrigued by its materiality and form as traces of their collective labor, rather than attempting to represent it. On the cover of the first issue of The Bitters Column, I put an image found in Garlic Press of three women with computer-heads. The women are in active conversation with one another, yet encapsulated in the personal computer. [Fig. 5]

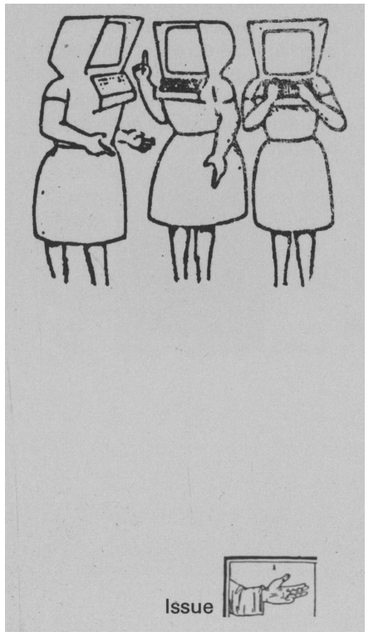

Fig. 5. Askerup, *The Bitters Column*, Issue 1, 2026.

The Bitters Column (TBC)[19] is a publication searching for hidden pasts by lifting the carpet and collecting cases swept away. Through its uttering, we might be able to hear the late and the latent, the in-process, the un-named, the un-paid, the longing, the invisible, the dormant—even if they seem to disappear again in its ephemeral matter and into oblivion.

Through weaving a feminist critical perspective into the publication, it becomes a site 'to form a practice'. I realised that woman's work corresponds to a particular organisation of time and space, that refers to the immediate and the everyday. In this sense, publishing—'making things public', is a performative and collaborative act, that asks for reclaiming this space. The Bitters Column continues in the coming issues with all parties involved: contributors, friends, and readers, making communities around the publication and its processes.

19. The Bitters Column has the abbreviation TBC, short for: to be confirmed and to be continued, and expands: to be copied, cut, conversed, compiled, collaborated, co-operated, complicated, cohabitated...

Askerup, Malva. *The Bitters Column*, Issue 2, 2026.

Brodine, Karen. *Woman Sitting at the Machine, Thinking*. Seattle: Red Letter Press, 1990.

Cockburn, Cynthia. *Brothers*. In *Male Dominance and Technological Change*, 118–40. London: Pluto Press, 1983.

Condorelli, Celine, and Avery F. Gordon. *The Company We Keep*. *PERSONA*, Issue 2 (2013): 14.

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Martinis Roe, Alex. *To Become Two: Propositions for Feminist Collective Practice*. Berlin: Archive Books, 2018.

Robertson, Lisa. *The Collective*. In *New Weathers*. Toronto: Book*hug Press, 2019.

Sutherland, Janet. *Karen Brodine: Poet, Feminist, Revolutionary, 1947–1987*. In *Freedom Socialist*, 1988.

Solomon, S. *Offsetting Queer Literary Labor*. Version 1. University of Sussex, 2018.

Scotford, Martha. *Messy History vs. Neat History: Toward an Expanded View of Women in Graphic Design*. *Visible Language* 28, no. 4 (1994): 368–88.

*Typeset in Olga Oppenheimer by the artist Bea Schlingelhoff, made available to the public in *Women against Hitler*, an exhibition at SCHLOSS, Oslo (2017), of typefaces dedicated to and named after women who fought the Nazi regime. In a text by Sadie Plant titled *On Bea Schlingelhoff 's typefaces for Women against Hitler* accompaning the exhibition, she writes: *Putting faces to the names of women of these types, who fought against the odds and mostly lost, is not a way to put them on display, in a frame or on a pedestal; it makes no effort to recover their stories and represent their lives, but intervenes at another point in the very infrastructure of communication in which these women also worked, as messengers, go-be-tweens, decoys and spies, maybe also as mothers or wives. It draws them out and turns them loose, extending their reach, putting them into circulation in another time, a different economy. It animates them, activates them, gives them currency. It honours and multiplies the things done in their names. It gives them faces once again.*

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